

The Power of the One Pager

Investors decide whether to take your call in less than 15 seconds. The one-pager is the document that has to survive that test.

A pitch deck wins the room. The one-pager wins the chance to be in the room. It travels in inboxes, sits on phone screens, and gets forwarded between partners — usually without you in the conversation.

Drawing on Pitchbird's work with thousands of founders, this guide distils the eight non-negotiables every one-pager needs, the four upgrades that turn competent into memorable, and the design principles that respect how investors actually read.

In the following pages, you'll learn:

- The 8 elements every one-pager must have
- The 4 high-leverage additions to consider
- How investors scan — and what to put where their eyes go
- When the one-pager helps and when it limits you

Magdalena Reith · Founder, Pitchbird

“Well-designed one-pagers turn cold inboxes into conversations that change everything.”



01: Why it matters

One sheet of paper. One decision.

The one-pager is the door, not the room. Done well, it earns you the meeting. Done badly, it earns you silence — and you'll never know which line lost you the deal.

A pitch deck wins the room. The one-pager wins the chance to be in the room. It travels in inboxes, sits on phone screens, and gets forwarded between partners — usually without you in the conversation.

That means every element has to do double duty: **introduce, intrigue, and stand on its own.**

32%

of decision-makers drop off after 15 seconds of reading a one-pager. The first impression is the only impression.

SOURCE · STORYDOC, 2024



Treat the one-pager as the most-circulated document you will ever make. Because it is.

02: The framework

The eight non-negotiables

If a one-pager misses any of these, it is incomplete. Treat this as the checklist before you send anything.

01

Company name & logo

Identity is the anchor. Investors know who they're dealing with before they read a single word.

02

Contact information

The most-skipped basic. If they can't reach you in one click, the document did nothing.

03

Company profile

A short, informative introduction — what you are, who you serve, why you exist.

04

Business idea

Describe the core concept in one tight sentence. No jargon, no hedging.

05

Unique selling proposition

What makes this venture distinct from the next ten emails in the inbox.

06

Roadmap & timeline

Graphically show where the business is going and when. Visual beats prose here.

07

Investment ask

The amount needed, the structure (one-time or tranches), and the deadline. Specific.

08

Investment highlights

The three or four reasons this allocation pays back. Punchy, not vague.



03: Beyond the basics

Add these if you have the space

The four below are the most common upgrades. Together, they turn a competent one-pager into a memorable one.

Problem



Frame the pain in market terms before you frame yourself.

Investors connect with the problem first. Make them feel it before you sell the cure.

Solution



Show how your business removes that pain. Two lines, max.

Lead with the outcome — not the mechanism. Save the how for the deck.

Traction



Prove customers want it. Revenue, signups, LOIs — whichever you have.

Proof beats promise. One data point trumps a paragraph of optimism.

Market



Who you sell to, and the competitive landscape they live in.

Investors want a beachhead, not 'everyone'. Show the wedge first.

04: Design principles

How investors actually read it



Content is king

Clarity first. Strong narrative — problem, solution, impact. Hierarchy via headings, sub-heads, and bullets that guide the eye.



Visually appealing

Clean composition, generous white space, strategic visuals over walls of text. Colour evokes brand, not chaos.



Remember your audience

Investors scan, not read. Lead with what helps their decision. Professional, confident tone throughout.



Call to action

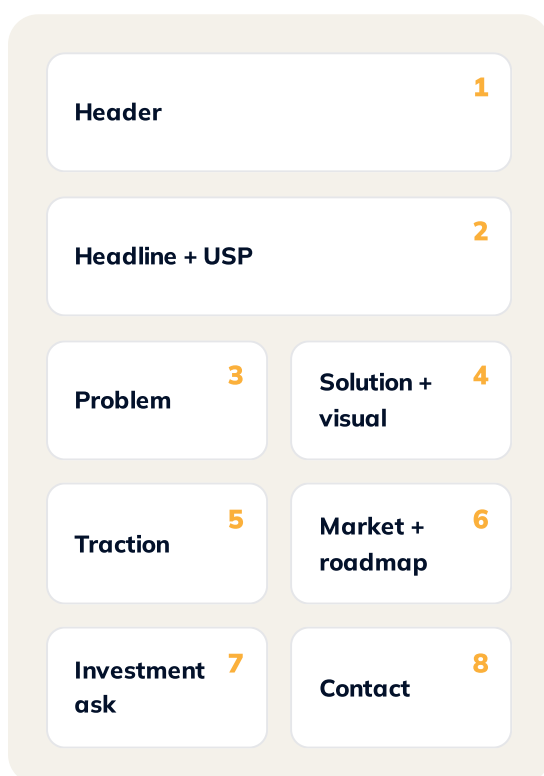
End with one specific ask. 'Schedule a 20-minute call.' Not 'we'd love to chat sometime.'



05: Anatomy

Where everything goes on the page

Investors don't read a one-pager — they scan it in a Z-shape, top-left to bottom-right. The eight elements earn their spot only when they sit where eyes already land.



1 Header

Logo + company name. Often the only thing the partner remembers ten minutes later — make it work.

2 Headline + USP

One sentence that earns the next 14 seconds of attention. Lead with the outcome, not the mechanism.

3 Problem

Pain in the customer's words. Numbers if you have them, story if you don't.

4 Solution + visual

How you remove the pain — paired with a mock-up, screenshot or icon. Visual carries weight here.

5 Traction

Proof. Revenue, signups, LOIs, pilots. One number beats a paragraph of optimism.

6 Market + roadmap

Beachhead first, then the trajectory. 6/12/24-month milestones in a single timeline.

7 Investment ask

The amount, the structure, the deadline. Specific. No 'flexible'.

8 Contact

Name, email, phone, LinkedIn. The most-skipped detail. Don't skip it.

06: Wisdom

Five lines worth living by

Hung on Pitchbird's studio wall. They're not pitch-deck tips — they're reminders for the weeks when the deal stalls and the founder forgets why the work is worth it.



You can't connect the dots looking forward; you can only connect them looking backwards. So you have to trust that the dots will somehow connect in your future.

STEVE JOBS

Founder, Apple



Chase the vision, not the money — the money will end up following you.

TONY HSIEH

Founder, Zappos



The best investment you can make is in your own knowledge.

WARREN BUFFETT

Berkshire Hathaway



My biggest motivation? Just to keep challenging myself.

RICHARD BRANSON

Founder, Virgin Group



Success is the journey where you reach and exist in places you never thought of before.

JAYSHREE CHHAJJER

Founder, Maitree Utsav



07: Measurement

Track what actually matters

A one-pager that no-one measures is a guess in a folder. Five signals tell you whether the document is doing the job — and which line in it is doing the heavy lifting.

Click-through rate



The percentage of recipients who clicked your CTA. The cleanest signal that the one-pager earned a next step.

Track per source — what works in DMs may flop in cold email.

Time on page



How long readers actually spend with it. Under 20 seconds = re-write. Over 90 = lower the density.

Pair with scroll depth before drawing conclusions.

Scroll depth



How far down they read. Cliffs in the curve show where attention drops — fix that section first.

Bottom-third drop-off is normal. Top-third drop-off is a red flag.

Conversion rate



The percentage who took the requested action — booked, replied, downloaded. The number you optimise everything else for.

If conv-rate is fine but absolute numbers are tiny, the gap is reach, not the page.

A/B testing



Run two versions in parallel. One change per test (headline, hero image, CTA copy). Decide on ≥ 30 events per arm.

Smaller decks need ranking judgements, not statistical significance.

08: Optimisation

Eight moves that compound

No single tweak doubles your conversion. Eight small tweaks, run with discipline over six weeks, almost always do. These are the moves we run in the Pitchbird studio whenever a one-pager underperforms.



Headline & hook

Test 3–5 versions. The best one outperforms the average by 2–3x — and you won't pick it intuitively.



Visual hierarchy

Move the most-skimmed elements to the top-left and bottom-right — that's where eyes actually land.



Content priority

Reorder by what the data says — not by what feels logical to the founder. Engagement signals beat outline-logic.



CTA testing

Position, colour, copy. 'Book a 15-min call' converts higher than 'Get in touch' on every cohort we've measured.



Personalisation

Swap the lede paragraph per investor persona. The rest stays. Drives 30–60% lifts on warm sends.



Mobile optimisation

Most first reads happen on a phone. If the headline wraps to four lines on mobile, the document is broken.



Channel integration

The one-pager and the email + DM and the deck all use the same headline, the same numbers, the same proof points. Consistency compounds.



Feedback loop

Ship, measure, edit, re-ship — weekly. The one-pager you send in month three should be unrecognisable from month one.

09: Further reading

Six books that sharpen the page

Pitchbird's recommended reading for founders writing — or rewriting — their one-pager. Brevity, story, and the discipline of leaving things out.



The One Page Proposal

PATRICK G. RILEY

The original framework. Forces you to defend every line on the page.



Made to Stick

CHIP & DAN HEATH

Why some ideas survive. Six principles — apply all of them to your one-pager.



Business Model Generation

OSTERWALDER & PIGNEUR

The Business Model Canvas — a different one-pager that pairs well with the investor version.



The Lean Startup

ERIC RIES

Validate before you polish. Your one-pager evolves with the business — let it.



The One Page Marketing Plan

ALLAN DIB

Marketing-focused, but the brevity discipline transfers directly to investor docs.



Storyworthy

MATTHEW DICKS

The 'homework for life' principle — find the moment in your founder story that actually lands.



10: Trade-offs

What it gives you — and what it can't

STRENGTHS

Respects the investor's time — and signals you respect it too.

Forces sharper thinking. If it doesn't fit on a page, the idea isn't focused yet.

Travels well — easy to forward, print, remember.

LIMITATIONS

Brevity is unforgiving. Every missing detail is a potential rejection.

Hard to write alone — outside eyes catch what founder-bias hides.

Not a substitute for the full deck. It is the door, not the room.



The one-pager is brutal in the right way. If your business doesn't fit on the page, the business isn't sharp yet.

**Want a Pitchbird review of
your one-pager?**

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